
A 12-week course you can repeat

WEEKLY WORKLOAD

Aim for four study sessions of 30-45 minutes and two slow practice games. If that is too much, stretch each week to two weeks. Consistency and review matter more than finishing on a deadline.

A 35-MINUTE SESSION

Spend 5 minutes recalling yesterday's position, 10 minutes learning one decision, 15 minutes calculating or playing a position, and 5 minutes writing the lesson. Keep the answer hidden during recall.

USE A MASTERY GATE

Move on when you can reconstruct the main branch, explain its plan and name the opponent's counterplay on two different days. If not, repeat the decision with a changed opposing reply.

DO NOT STUDY EVERY BRANCH EQUALLY

Prioritize the first line of each family and the lines your opponents play. Optional alternatives are comparison material after the main repertoire is stable.

Weeks 1-3

WEEK 1 / BOARD SKILLS AND THINKING ROUTINE

00 foundations; practice coordinates, legal moves, notation and the blunder check. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 2 / FIRST OPENING FAMILY

01 family 1. Learn its main route, then two alternatives. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 3 / SECOND OPENING FAMILY

01 family 2. Compare the opponent's central choices. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 4-6

WEEK 4 / THIRD OPENING FAMILY

01 family 3. Add common deviations and one warning position. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 5 / FOURTH FAMILY AND BOUNDARIES

01 family 4. Distinguish the main repertoire from optional branches and bridges. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 6 / PAWN STRUCTURES

02 strategic lessons 1-4. Identify the correct break from the actual center. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 7-9

WEEK 7 / DEFENSE AND TACTICS

02 remaining lessons and calculation audits. Practice checks, captures and opponent resources. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 8 / FIRST THREE LABORATORIES

03 laboratories 1-3. Play each starting position from both sides. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 9 / LAST THREE LABORATORIES

03 laboratories 4-6. Compare candidates before revealing the engine lines. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 10-12

WEEK 10 / ENDGAME TRANSITIONS

02 endgames. Analyze one legal exchange sequence from your own game. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 11 / FULL RETRIEVAL TEST

04 questions 1-48. Write explanations before looking at answers. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 12 / CONSOLIDATE YOUR OWN REPERTOIRE

Repair recurring errors and build a small personal file of the positions you actually meet. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Pocket reference / 1

ACCEPTED: THE G-PAWN DEFENSES

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

KG-01 The main choice: meet ...g5 with h4

Attack the pawn chain, then move the attacked knight.

KG-02 Kieseritzky: the developing ...Nf6

Count both sides' captures, not just the pawn you recovered.

KG-03 Kieseritzky: an immediate ...d6

An attacked piece may escape by capturing a target.

KG-04 Black reinforces with ...h6

Calculate the h-file before choosing the recapture.

KG-05 Black develops the bishop early

Track a pawn's new file after every capture.

KG-06 Quiet alternative: the Vienna-style approach

A development move can concede a forcing pawn tempo.

KG-07 Fischer Defense: build the center

...d6 changes the knight's retreat square.

KG-08 Fischer Defense: Black develops first

If the pawn is returned, play the resulting position.

Pocket reference / 2

ACCEPTED: CENTRAL AND DEVELOPING DEFENSES

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

KG-09 Modern Defense: ...d5 at once

Central counterplay can matter more than retaining the extra pawn.

KG-10 Modern Defense: the queen recaptures

Gain a tempo and spend it on development.

KG-11 Abbazia: an early pawn exchange

A check can help the defender develop.

KG-12 Schalopp Defense

An offside knight may still perform a concrete defensive job.

KG-13 Cunningham: meet the bishop check

Surviving the check changes the whole king-safety plan.

KG-14 Cunningham: Black chooses ...Nf6

Count attackers and defenders on f2 as well as f7.

KG-15 The ...Nc6 developing defense

Development with tempo must still be tactically safe.

KG-16 The ...h6 waiting move

Match the position, not just the opening name.

Pocket reference / 3

DECLINED AND COUNTERGAMBITS

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

KG-17 Classical Declined: ...Bc5

Respect the diagonal before taking e5.

KG-18 Declined: ...Bc5 with ...Nc6

A declined gambit can become a normal development contest.

KG-19 Falkbeer: the ...e4 wedge

Challenge the wedge before it binds your pieces.

KG-20 Falkbeer transposes to the Modern

Transpose by position, including whose turn it is.

KG-21 Falkbeer: ...c6 counter gambit

You do not have to accept a second gambit.

KG-22 Declined with ...d6

Gain space, then finish development.

KG-23 Declined with ...Nc6

The opening can change family a move later.

KG-24 The ...f5 counter gambit

Against counter gambits, check forcing moves first.

Pocket reference / 4

ALTERNATIVES AND REPERTOIRE BOUNDARIES

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

KG-25 Bishop's Gambit: optional route

Bc4 first permits the check Nf3 would prevent.

KG-26 Muzio: understand the sacrifice

Distinguish a deliberate piece sacrifice from normal development.

KG-27 Simple warning: the exposed king

Check the queen's diagonal before chasing a pawn.

KG-28 If Black plays the French

No ...e5 means no King's Gambit.

KG-29 If Black plays the Caro-Kann

Choose a real response to Black's first move.

KG-30 If Black plays the Sicilian

A bridge line has a defined move-order boundary.

KG-31 If Black plays the Scandinavian

Meet a central challenge with development and calculation.

KG-32 If Black plays a modern setup

Take space, then make it sustainable.

A practical game-analysis worksheet

GAME DETAILS

Date: _____ Opponent: _____ Time control: _____ Result: _____

FIRST UNFAMILIAR POSITION

Move number: _____ Relevant line ID: _____

What did the opponent's last move threaten? Write the FEN or save the position in your chess program.

MY CANDIDATES

Candidate A and a reply: _____

Candidate B and a reply: _____

Why did I choose the move I played?

DIAGNOSIS

Was the main error opening recall, missed tactics, the wrong pawn break, king safety, an exchange decision or time management? Choose the earliest cause that explains the later problem.

REPAIR

Write one concrete rule tied to the position. Add a short legal variation and schedule the next review. Do not add twenty engine moves that you cannot explain.

Glossary

ANCHOR

The authored move sequence defining a branch; later printed moves may be an illustrative continuation.

COMPENSATION

Activity, king pressure or structural advantages that may offset a material deficit.

COUNTERPLAY

Active threats or pressure that make the opponent address your ideas.

EN PRISE

A piece is available to be captured; check whether the capture is actually safe.

FIANCHETTO

Developing a bishop to b2, g2, b7 or g7 behind a moved b- or g-pawn.

INITIATIVE

The ability to pose threats that influence the opponent's replies.

ISOLATED PAWN

A pawn with no friendly pawn on either adjacent file.

Glossary / continued

MINORITY ATTACK

A pawn advance by fewer pawns against a larger pawn group to create weaknesses.

OUTPOST

A useful supported square for a piece, often difficult for enemy pawns to challenge.

PROPHYLAXIS

A move that anticipates and reduces the opponent's useful plan.

TEMPO

One move of time; useful tempi are gained when threats force helpful replies.

TRANSPOSITION

Different move orders reaching the same position with the same side to move and relevant rights.

ZWISCHENZUG

An intermediate move, often forcing, played before an expected recapture.

Sources and attribution

OPENING NAMES AND ROUTES

Lichess chess-openings is a CC0 reference for established names and entry move orders. The course commentary, study routes and practice curriculum are original. Some Hippo routes use descriptive teaching labels because opening-name databases use that term inconsistently.

<https://github.com/lichess-org/chess-openings>

ENGINE AND LEGAL-MOVE TOOLS

Stockfish 18 supplies finite tactical comparisons and illustrative continuations. python-chess 1.11.2 validates moves, positions and PGN.

<https://stockfishchess.org/download/>

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/>

PIECE ARTWORK

The Cburnett piece designs are by Colin M. L. Burnett, as distributed by python-chess. Adapted SVG sources, attribution and the GPL-2.0 license are included in Artwork_Credits_and_Sources. The palette and PDF drawing scale are adjusted; the original piece silhouettes are retained.

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/en/latest/svg.html>

Research scope and verification

KING'S GAMBIT CONTEXT

The Modern Defense accepts f4 and challenges the center with ...d5, often returning material for development. This source was used for context; the detailed branches and explanations here were independently constructed.

<https://www.chess.com/openings/Kings-Gambit-Accepted-Modern-Defense>

WHAT WAS CHECKED

All 130 course anchors across the five courses were legally replayed. Repertoire-side decisions after the opening commitment received 80,000-node best-move and played-move comparisons; apparent losses above 1.00 were rechecked at 600,000 nodes. Flagged choices were revised. Warning lines deliberately contain mistakes and are marked.

ILLUSTRATIONS AND LIMITS

Short anchors were extended to about move ten using 140,000-node searches. Endpoints used 400,000 nodes; laboratory positions used 500,000 nodes per search. These are finite checks, not proofs of equality or exhaustive modern theory. Optional gambits and full Hippo formations retain practical and strategic risks.

WHAT THE NUMBERS MEAN

Laboratory estimates are expressed from your course side's perspective, so higher is better for that side. They are not literal pawn counts or guaranteed winning probabilities. Close candidate values should be treated as comparable, and deeper analysis may change the ordering.

PUBLICATION CHECKS

PDF text, page geometry, board legality and PGN replay are checked. Every combined-volume page is rendered for visual review. The supplied verification manifest records the final page counts and file hashes.